The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Kaja Kallas, the vice-president of the European Commission, rejected America's assertion, made in a national-defence document last year, that Europe is facing "civilizational erasure". Ms Kallas was speaking at the Munich Security Conference, where a day earlier Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, won over the audience by playing up ties between the allies.

Karol Nawrocki, Poland's president, told Polsat, a news channel, that his country should work towards "joining the nuclear project", citing "the aggressive, imperial attitude of Russia toward Poland". The Munich Security Conference was abuzz with talk of **nuclear proliferation**. Estonia's prime minister and Latvia's deputy defence minister both contemplated the once-taboo idea, while Friedrich Merz, Germany's chancellor, said France and Germany were discussing a European nuclear deterrent.

Herman Halushchenko, a former Ukrainian minister, was arrested while trying to leave the country. Mr Halushchenko was one of several senior officials to resign last year after being implicated in an alleged $100m embezzlement scheme. Separately, Volodymyr Zelensky, the president, said on Saturday that **Ukraine** needed

“two months of ceasefire” to hold an election, which America has been pushing for as a condition of continued security guarantees.

Israeli air strikes killed at least nine people in **Gaza** on Sunday, according to Palestinian officials. Israel said that the attacks are retaliation for Hamas having violated a ceasefire agreement a day earlier. At least 500 Palestinians have been killed since the militant group that controls the territory agreed to lay down arms in October.

American forces **interdicted** and boarded a ship in the Indian ocean, according to the Pentagon. The *Veronica III*, a vessel under sanctions, left the coast of Venezuela with a hold full of oil on January 3rd, the day that America’s armed forces captured Nicolás Maduro, the country’s dictator. It is the second **oil tanker** carrying Venezuelan oil that America has seized this month.

Yvette Cooper, Britain’s foreign secretary, threatened sanctions against Russia after five European countries said it was “highly likely” that a poison developed from the Ecuador dart frog killed **Alexei Navalny**, a Russian opposition leader. They blamed the Kremlin for his death, two years ago, in a Siberian penal colony. The Russian government denied the accusation, describing it as the “feeble-mindedness of Western fabulists”.

Organisers indefinitely postponed **Cuba’s** annual **cigar festival**, which was scheduled for the end of February, blaming America’s fuel blockade. In January the Trump administration placed an effective embargo on foreign-oil shipments to the island, which has suffered power cuts and shortened the working week. In 2025 the festival’s cigar auction yielded more than $18m, which apparently supports Cuba’s health-care system.

Word of the week: Alpha, the name of a Christian starter course that has become one of Britain’s most successful cultural exports. Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

The rift between Washington and Jerusalem

Binyamin Netanyahu's emergency visit to the White House disappointed him. On Wednesday Israel's prime minister urged Donald Trump not to seek a nuclear agreement with Iran. In a post after their meeting America's president wrote, "I insisted that negotiations with Iran continue to see whether or not a Deal can be consummated." In a rare show of discord between the two leaders, Mr Netanyahu said before returning to Israel that he had not hidden his "general scepticism about the possibility of reaching any agreement with Iran".

Israel fears that a deal would focus on Iran's nuclear programme, which was significantly damaged by Israeli and American bombing in June, rather than on its ballistic-missile arsenal, which Iran has used to attack Israel. Mr Trump, who said he was sending a second aircraft-carrier to the region, is for now keeping his options open.

Photograph: AP

The limits of MAGA solidarity

On Sunday, after attending the Munich Security Conference, Marco Rubio is going to Slovakia and then to Hungary. But it's not clear whether he will meet Viktor Orban, the Hungarian prime minister, who is both Russia-friendly and an admirer of the Trump administration's anti-immigration policies.

Mr Orban would no doubt welcome a photo-op with the American secretary of state. He is fighting to be re-elected in a parliamentary vote scheduled for April 12th. Donald Trump has endorsed him. However, neither MAGA backing nor Mr Rubio's visit to Budapest is likely to influence the election much. Hungarian voters care mainly about the sorry state of the economy and health-care system and about corruption. Neither Mr Trump nor J.D. Vance, his vice-president, is expected to visit Budapest before the election.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weaponising cricket in south Asia

India and Pakistan can’t play a game of cricket against one another without politics getting in the way. But even by their antsy standards, the build up to Sunday’s clash in the Twenty20 World Cup, in which India thrashed Pakistan, was torturous.

The row centred around Bangladesh. The governments of India and Bangladesh fell out when Bangladesh’s despotic prime minister, Sheikh Hasina, was ousted in 2024. In January India’s cricket board forced a domestic team to sack a Bangladeshi player. Bangladesh then demanded its World Cup games be moved from India to Sri Lanka. The sport’s India-dominated governing body kicked them out of the tournament.

Enter Pakistan, which said it would forfeit its game against India in solidarity. Given that India-Pakistan games are one of the most-watched sporting contests on the planet—and thus extremely lucrative—that was a severe threat. On Monday, however, Pakistan agreed to play. After all the posturing, some sport was a nice change.

Photograph: National Gallery of Art, Washington D.C

The seascapes of Georges Seurat

Georges Seurat is known for grand, luminous paintings of Parisian life, such as “A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of La Grande Jatte”. The French artist pioneered the pointillist technique, using small dots and dashes of colour to create his pictures. Yet more than half of the paintings Seurat finished in his short life were of the sea.

The Courtauld Gallery in London has put Seurat’s seascapes on show together for the first time, assembling around 23 paintings and a few drawings. Every summer from 1885 to 1890 Seurat escaped his studio in Paris for the sea. Visiting Grandchamp, Honfleur, Port-en-Bessin, Le Crotoy and Gravelines, he captured the cliffs, beaches and ports of France’s northern coast. On his trips he sought to capture “the bright light, in all its nuances”. The effect, as captured in this sublime exhibition, is a collection of canvases that brim with pearly grey and blue.

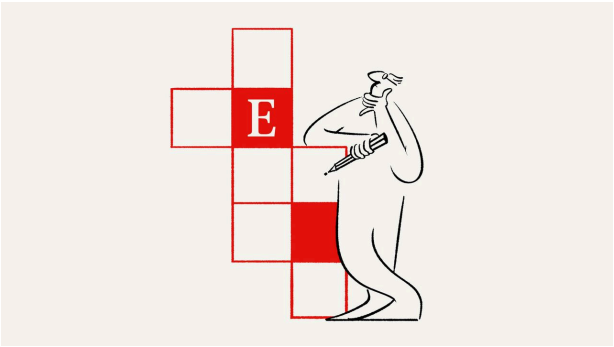

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Military garb sounds like it will get your motor running (5)

2 across - Propose a flat surface (5)

3 across - An Aussie pickup with some road ahead knows where to go (5)

1 down - I'm a streaker, weirdly, for Britain's first among equals (4,7)

Straight clues

1 across - The army's favourite shade (5)

2 across - An elementary display of facts or figures (5)

3 across - The right direction (5)

1 down - SW1A's most powerful knight, for now (4,7)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Guillaume Laroch, Calgary, Canada

Maria Manuela DaCosta, Eau Claire,aq Wisconsin, America

Sverre Prytz, Zurich, Switzerland

They gave the right answers of The Ugly Duckling, Alcatraz, Wales, Prince Harry and Madison Square Garden. The theme is Clint Eastwood films: "The Good, the Bad and the Ugly", "Escape from Alcatraz", "The Outlaw Josey Wales", "Dirty Harry" and "The Bridges of Madison County".

The questions were:

Monday: In which Hans Christian Andersen tale does the main character turn out to be a swan?

Tuesday: Which American prison was home to both Al Capone and Machine Gun Kelly?

Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of Britain?

Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

Friday: Which Manhattan venue is home to the New York Knicks?

Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did, and it never will.

Frederick Douglass